5-STRING BANJO · OLD-TIME TUNINGS

StroboClip HDC Tuning Card

Tunings, names, and tuner order match Tom Collins's Banjo Quest.

OLD TIME BANJO CONFIGURATION **OTB**

A = 440 Hz · sweetened thirds · v5 · October 30, 2026

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Strings: 5th (drone) → 1st. **Shading:** semitones moved from G Standard, up or down. **–6.8¢** sweetened (cents). **Chip:** tuner color *(why)*.

#	CODE	TUNING	5TH	4TH	3RD	2ND	1ST	NOTES
1	GST	**G Standard** gDGBD key of G *white for plain standard*	G4	D3	G3	B3 –6.8¢	D4	Reference. Shading marks strings moved from here.
2	OLG	**Old G / Sandy River Belle** gDGDE key of G *yellow for sand*	G4	D3	G3	D4 +3	E4 +2	Last Chance, a whole step up (capo 2).
3	DBC	**Double C** gCGCD key of C *light blue for C, the sea*	G4	C3 –2	G3	C4 +1	D4	
4	SAW	**Sawmill** gDGCD key of G *tan for sawdust*	G4	D3	G3	C4 +1	D4	
5	AST	**A Standard** aEAC#E key of A *white, like G Standard*	A4 +2	E3 +2	A3 +2	C♯4 +2 –6.8¢	E4 +2	G Standard, a whole step up (capo 2).
6	DBD	**Double D** aDADE key of D *light blue, like Double C*	A4 +2	D3	A3 +2	D4 +3	E4 +2	Double C, a whole step up (capo 2).
7	AML	**A Modal** aEADE key of A *tan, like Sawmill*	A4 +2	E3 +2	A3 +2	D4 +3	E4 +2	Sawmill, a whole step up (capo 2).
8	SSR	**Sawmill: Sandy River** gEADE key of G *cyan for the river*	G4	E3 +2	A3 +2	D4 +3	E4 +2	
9	OLC	**Old C** gCGBD key of C *yellow, like Old G*	G4	C3 –2	G3	B3 –6.8¢	D4	
10	OR1	**Old Reuben 1** g#EG#BE key of E *light green*	G♯4 +1 –6.8¢	E3 +2	G♯3 +1 –6.8¢	B3	E4 +2	
11	OR2	**Old Reuben 2** f#DF#AD key of D *light green, like OR1*	F♯4 –1 –6.8¢	D3	F♯3 –1 –6.8¢	A3 –2	D4	Old Reuben 1, a whole step down (capo 2 = OR1).
12	GMI	**G Minor** gDGBbD key of G *orchid for minor*	G4	D3	G3	B♭3 –1 +7.8¢	D4	Shows B♭ (set to flats).
13	CG1	**Cumberland Gap 1** g#C#F#BE key of E *green for the mountains*	G♯4 +1 –6.8¢	C♯3 –1	F♯3 –1	B3	E4 +2	
14	CG2	**Cumberland Gap 2** f#BEAD key of D *green for the mountains*	F♯4 –1 –6.8¢	B2 –3	E3 –3	A3 –2	D4	Cumberland Gap 1, a whole step down (capo 2 = CG1).
15	LGN	**Lost Gander** f#DEAD key of D *red, like Frankie Baker*	F♯4 –1 –6.8¢	D3	E3 –3	A3 –2	D4	
16	FKB	**Frankie Baker** g#EF#BE key of E *red for the murder ballad*	G♯4 +1 –6.8¢	E3 +2	F♯3 –1	B3	E4 +2	Lost Gander, a whole step up (capo 2).
17	LCH	**Last Chance** fCFCD key of F *lime for the last green light*	F4 –2	C3 –2	F3 –2	C4 +1	D4	
18	CCC	**Triple C** gCGCC key of C *lilac, unlike Double C*	G4	C3 –2	G3	C4 +1	C4 –2	2nd and 1st are both C4 (unison).
19	BER	**Big Eyed Rabbit** fFGCD key of F *pink for the rabbit*	F4 –2	F3 +3	G3	C4 +1	D4	
20	PNW	**Piney Woods** gGDGB key of G *green for the pines*	G4	G2 –7	D3 –5	G3 –4	B3 –3 –6.8¢	4th string drops to low G (G2).

ON THE TUNER

Change tuning: click **Menu** until the code flashes, step with **+** / **–**, then **Menu** again (or wait).

Back to EQU (plain chromatic): while the code flashes, press **+** and **–** together.

Order: EQU, then rows 1–20 (Auto-Order off). Factory presets: Settings › Configuration › dEF.

Menu ×2 color · **×3** drop/capo · **×4** Concert A, each saved with the active tuning.

Each tuning listens only for its own notes. A string that is far off reads as the nearest note in the tuning, so check the note name as well as the strobe.
Sweetened notes: those marked –6.8¢ sit 6.8 cents flat (Peterson's half-tempered value for a major third), to smooth selected open-string intervals; G Minor's B♭ is 7.8 cents sharp. Just tune until the strobe stops.

What OTB Is and How to Use It

OTB

1 What this is

OTB is a set of 20 old-time banjo tunings loaded onto a Peterson StroboClip HDC as one configuration. The tunings are the common ones nearly every old-time player uses; their names and order follow Tom Collins's Banjonomicon tool at Banjo Quest (atlas.banjoquest.com), so his students see one list. Select a tuning and the tuner takes that tuning's color and keeps it. Pluck a string and the tuner shows the note in that tuning nearest to what it hears; turn the peg until the strobe stands still. The tuning table on page 1 lists all 20.

2 Which tuners

Made on the StroboClip HDC. The HDC-B and HDC-V are the same tuner with different clips, so OTB loads on them too. The 20 tunings are also shared one by one for other Peterson tuners that work with Peterson Connect, such as the StroboPLUS HDC and the StroboClip HD. The OTB page linked below lists what carries over to each model.

3 Get it onto your tuner

You need the tuner, a USB cable, a computer running a supported web browser, and a free account at petersontuners.com. Plug in the tuner, open the User Trading Post at petersontuners.com/sweeteners/shared, find OTB under Shared User Configurations, and click Add to My Tuner. Installing may replace your existing custom configuration. The factory presets are never lost: on the tuner, Settings, then Configuration, then dEF brings them back. A step-by-step guide with screenshots is at the link below.

4 Pick a tuning and tune

Click Menu until the three-letter code flashes, step with + or – to the code you want, and let it settle. Pluck one string at a time. The tuner shows the note it hears; turn the peg until the letter matches the table and the strobe stands still. Come up to pitch from below.

5 Reading the tuning table

Each row is one tuning: the code and color the tuner shows, the name, the tuning as players write it with the 5th string first, and the key. The five columns are the strings, from the 5th, the short drone, to the 1st, and each cell is the note that string should read, with its octave as a small digit after the letter; G2 is the lowest note on the card. Shading and the signed whole numbers below a note show how many semitones that string moved from G Standard, so G Standard has no shading. Green –6.8¢ marks a sweetened note.

6 Sweetened, or plain EQU

A cent is one hundredth of a semitone. The notes marked –6.8¢ sit 6.8 cents flat, a shade rather than a step: Peterson's half-tempered value for a major third, which lets the open strings ring smoother together. G Minor's B♭ is 7.8 cents sharp for the same reason. Fretted notes on a sweetened string move with it. Select one of the eleven tunings with an offset and the tuner shows SWEETENER in small letters above the code; the nine with none show nothing there.

If you would rather not sweeten, or you are playing with a piano or accordion, use EQU, the plain chromatic preset: equal temperament, all twelve notes, no sweetening, any instrument. Press + and – together while a code flashes to reach it.

7 Four things that catch people out

- A string that is far off can read as another note in the tuning with a still strobe. Select Piney Woods with the banjo still in G Standard and the 4th string reads a steady D; its target is low G. Check the letter against the table before you trust the strobe.
- On big moves, get close by ear first, then let the tuner finish. Piney Woods drops the 4th string seven semitones.
- Seven tunings are a whole step above another one; the table's notes say which. Reaching the higher one is the same job either way: tune all five strings up two semitones, or stay in the lower tuning and capo at the 2nd fret, which raises the four long strings by the same two semitones. The 5th string sits above the capo, so raise it two semitones by hand or hook it under a spike at the 7th fret. Then select the higher tuning on the tuner; it checks what it hears, capo or not.
- Weak or jumpy readings, most often on the short 5th string, which ends far from the headstock: try clipping the tuner to the rim of the pot instead. The headstock works; the rim is a little steadier.

Do not let the tuner stop you from listening. Tuning by ear is still tuning; the strobe is there to confirm it.

8 Latest version of this card, and more about the tunings and the tuner

mmarmor.github.io/stroboclip-old-time-banjo: this card, kept current, in US Letter and A4; the step-by-step loading guide; notes on the tunings and the tuner.
Tuner presets: **petersontuners.com/sweeteners/shared** (User Trading Post, Shared User Configurations, OTB).

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